The Man Who Stopped Wanting

Ethics and Economics — Storytelling Presentation Script Target duration: 25–30 minutes | Setting: Contemporary India

> *[!NOTE]* ***Performance note:*** *Speak slowly at marked pauses. Let the dialogue do the work. Theory enters only through brief narrator lines — never as a lecture. Each idea appears once and is never restated.*

OPENING — A Pencil on Paper | 0:00–2:30

VISUAL: Black screen. Then a notebook on a desk. Written in a teenager's handwriting: *"One day, I want to study engineering."* A ceiling fan. A window. Traffic outside.

NARRATOR:

Let me begin with a person, not a theory.

Aarav is seventeen. He lives in a crowded neighbourhood in contemporary India. He is good at mathematics. He likes pulling apart broken gadgets and figuring out how they work.

> ***Aarav:*** *I want to study engineering.*

It is not an extraordinary dream. But a dream is two things: something you *want*, and something you believe might be *possible*.

> ***Mother:*** *First, let us see how we manage the next few months.*

[Show the notebook across three evenings: open; half-buried under receipts; closed under a tool bag.]

Nobody bans Aarav from studying. The household simply needs income now. His father's work is irregular. Coaching costs money. Time runs out before the day does. Aarav starts helping at Sharma uncle's electronics repair shop.

He still studies at night. Then less. Then not at all.

This story is about what happens next — not to his career, but to his desire.

THE LIFE — Two Years in Nine Moments | 2:30–14:00

VISUAL: The repair shop. Months and seasons pass through the window behind Aarav. Each episode flows directly into the next.

[SIX MONTHS IN]

Neeraj, his oldest friend, visits the shop.

> ***Neeraj:*** *Still preparing for the entrance exam?*
>
> ***Aarav:*** *No. I've stopped.*
>
> ***Neeraj:*** *Why?*
>
> ***Aarav:*** *What's the point? Engineering costs money. Even if you get through, there's no guarantee of a job. Here I'm learning something real. I earn. I help at home. It's better.*

NARRATOR: A fox reaches for grapes, fails, and decides they must be sour. Aarav reaches for engineering, cannot afford it, and decides it must not be worth it. Jon Elster calls this *adaptive preference formation* — the central mechanism in *Sour Grapes*. The frustration of wanting something inaccessible is resolved by wanting it less.

[SAME WEEK]

But the same deprivation does something completely different to Aarav's friend Deepa. She wants to become a doctor. Her family cannot afford it either. But Deepa does not let go. She becomes consumed.

> ***Deepa:*** *I don't care how long it takes. Nothing else matters.*
>
> ***Aarav:*** *You haven't eaten properly in two days.*
>
> ***Deepa:*** *You gave up. I won't.*

NARRATOR: Elster calls this *counteradaptive preference* — the exact opposite of sour grapes. The forbidden fruit tastes sweetest. Deepa inflates the value of medicine *because* it is denied. Same deprivation, opposite response. Neither is simply rational.

[NINE MONTHS IN]

Aarav's uncle arranges a two-month placement at a small manufacturing unit in the city. Aarav assists the engineers. He watches their daily work — the paperwork, the office politics, the distance between elegant mathematics and the mundane reality of the job.

He comes back.

> ***Mother:*** *How was the city?*
>
> ***Aarav:*** *Different from what I imagined. The engineers sit at computers filling forms. I fixed more things in one week at the shop than they fix in a month.*

NARRATOR: This is what Elster, drawing on Amartya Sen, calls *preference change through learning*. Aarav has now experienced both alternatives. His preference for repair work is no longer based on imagination — it is based on evidence. Learning requires exposure. Without it, a preference may rest on ignorance of what was missed.

[ONE YEAR IN]

One evening, Aarav hears a rumour that a local trust may offer scholarships soon. The old pull returns — a flicker. But he knows that if he starts hoping again and fails, the disappointment will break him.

> ***Aarav:*** *(to his mother) If anyone brings me a scholarship form in the next three months, hide it. I need to finish the busy season first. I'll decide in January. Not before.*

NARRATOR: *Precommitment*: deliberately restricting your own future choices to protect a clearer decision later. Odysseus binds himself to the mast. Aarav asks his mother to hide the form. He is not changing his desire. He is managing the timing. This is strategy, not surrender.

[THIRTEEN MONTHS IN]

Sharma uncle — the shop owner — is shrewd. Aarav is his best worker. He does not want to lose him. Over weeks, he plants seeds.

> ***Sharma:*** *You know, these engineers think they're above us. But who do they come to when their laptops break? Us.*
>
> ***Aarav:*** *That's true.*
>
> ***Sharma:*** *College boys can't hold a screwdriver. Stay here. Five years, I'll make you a partner.*

NARRATOR: The partnership offer is real. But Sharma uncle's motive is not Aarav's welfare — it is keeping a skilled worker. Elster calls this *manipulation*: an external agent deliberately shaping someone's preferences for the manipulator's advantage. Unlike sour grapes, which happens inside a person's own mind, manipulation is social and intentional. Someone else is pulling the thread.

[FIFTEEN MONTHS IN]

A quiet night. Aarav sits on the roof with a tattered book his old teacher lent him. He thinks about duty. About what kind of person he wants to become.

> ***Aarav:*** *(to Neeraj, the next day) I've been thinking. I don't want to spend my life chasing something I may never get. I want to find meaning in what's in front of me. My family. My craft. This neighbourhood.*
>
> ***Neeraj:*** *That sounds like giving up with extra steps.*
>
> ***Aarav:*** *Giving up is when you stop wanting something because it hurts. This is different. I'm choosing what to care about.*

NARRATOR: *Character planning*: the deliberate, reflective cultivation of one's own desires. Aarav is forming a second-order preference — a desire *about* his desires. He does not merely stop wanting engineering; he *wants* to stop wanting it, and he has reasons he has examined. The difficulty: from the outside, character planning and adaptive preferences look identical.

[EIGHTEEN MONTHS IN]

Aarav's father collapses at work. Three weeks in hospital. Medical bills eat through savings. Aarav works double shifts.

> ***Mother:*** *I'm sorry. I know you wanted—*
>
> ***Aarav:*** *Don't. This is what matters.*

NARRATOR: Before the hospital, Aarav weighed two things: intellectual challenge and family security. Challenge came first. Now family security dominates everything. He looks at the same two options but weighs the *attributes* differently. Elster calls this *prior change of attribute weights*. The question is whether the crisis revealed something genuine about his values — or whether deprivation forced one priority to drown out the others.

[TWENTY MONTHS IN]

A brief detour. Aarav's neighbour Ravi once dreamed of becoming a cricketer. When that door closed, Ravi started drinking. Now Ravi's only daily priority is the next drink.

> ***Aarav:*** *(watching Ravi stumble past) He used to be the best batsman on the street.*

NARRATOR: *Addiction*: a preference that has escaped rational control. Ravi has not chosen, reflected, or adapted. His desires have been captured. Elster places addiction on the same map as the other mechanisms — it too produces preference change. But here the person has *lost* autonomy rather than exercised it.

[TWO YEARS IN]

The family is stable again. Aarav has settled into routine. Neeraj shows him a newspaper article: engineering graduates in their state have an 82% employment rate.

> ***Aarav:*** *That can't be right. Everyone knows engineers are unemployed.*
>
> ***Neeraj:*** *It says 82%. Look.*
>
> ***Aarav:*** *Newspapers print what they want.*

NARRATOR: *Rationalization*. Aarav has not changed what he wants — he has changed what he *believes about the facts*. His desire for a good career is intact. But his map of reality has been quietly redrawn to make the detour feel like the main road.

> ***Neeraj:*** *And if money weren't a problem? If someone paid for everything?*
>
> ***Aarav:*** *(long pause) Maybe. But money is a problem. So why think about it?*

NARRATOR: And this is *state-dependent preference*. In his current condition — financial pressure, family obligation — Aarav's desires are chained to what is urgent. If the condition changed, the preference might change too. When a state persists long enough, the chain becomes invisible.

[VISUAL: Fade to Aarav locking up the shop at the end of an ordinary day. He is not miserable. He is not heroic. He is managing.]

Nine moments. Nine forces that moved a want. Some preserved Aarav's autonomy. Some eroded it. Some are ambiguous. And all nine produced the same outward result: a man who says he is fine.

THE KNOCK — A Scholarship Arrives | 14:00–18:30

VISUAL: Aarav at the shop counter. Phone buzzes. A scholarship announcement — tuition covered, study expenses assisted. He is eligible.

SOUND: Notification. Then silence.

> ***Neeraj:*** *Aarav. You should apply.*
>
> ***Aarav:*** *No.*
>
> ***Neeraj:*** *You haven't even read it.*
>
> ***Aarav:*** *I have work here.*
>
> ***Neeraj:*** *But you wanted this.*
>
> ***Aarav:*** *That was years ago. I changed.*
>
> ***Neeraj:*** *Or did the choices available to you change first?*

[Aarav turns on him.]

> ***Aarav:*** *You think you understand my life because you remember what I wanted at seventeen?*
>
> ***Neeraj:*** *I'm not deciding for you. I'm asking.*
>
> ***Aarav:*** *Then ask without already knowing the answer.*

[SILENCE. Five full seconds.]

Later that evening — a different conversation.

> ***Mother:*** *Do you want to apply?*
>
> ***Aarav:*** *I don't know.*
>
> ***Mother:*** *Would you go if the money were enough?*
>
> ***Aarav:*** *Maybe. But then who helps here? What if I fail? Everyone will say I wasted the chance.*
>
> ***Mother:*** *Those are real worries.*
>
> ***Aarav:*** *I'm not afraid of studying. I'm tired of building my life around a possibility that might not work.*
>
> ***Mother:*** *Then maybe the question is not whether you want to study. It is whether studying can be made possible without everything else collapsing.*

NARRATOR:

His mother has reframed the problem. Not *"What do you desire?"* but *"What can actually be made available to you?"*

Amartya Sen, in *On Ethics and Economics*, argues that evaluating a person's well-being only through their satisfaction — through utility — gives us an incomplete picture. A person can be content and still lack freedoms that matter. Happiness is real evidence, but it is not the whole of a life.

Sen asks us to look at the *opportunities and real freedoms* available to a person, not only at what they report feeling. Aarav's satisfaction is not fake. His skill and family contribution are genuine. But so is the question of whether he has a meaningful chance to pursue education if he decides he wants it.

The utilitarian asks: *Is he satisfied?* Sen asks: *What can he actually do and be?*

PRESENTING THIN AND BROAD RATIONALITY

[VISUAL: Split the screen into two columns.]

THIN RATIONALITY	**BROAD RATIONALITY**
Does this person act consistently with what they believe and want?	*How did they come to believe and want those things?*

> ***Neeraj:*** *(voiceover) Aarav says he doesn't want engineering. He acts accordingly — he works at the shop, he supports his family, he doesn't apply. His beliefs, desires, and actions are perfectly consistent. By the standard of thin rationality, there is nothing wrong.*

[Beat.]

> ***Mother:*** *(voiceover) But I watched those beliefs form. I watched the notebook close. I watched the ambition shrink. The question is not whether he acts on what he wants. The question is whether what he wants was shaped by conditions that gave him no real choice.*

[Beat.]

NARRATOR:

Thin rationality checks for *consistency*. Broad rationality checks for *formation*. A person can pass the first test — their actions match their preferences — while failing the second — their preferences were never freely formed.

Elster's nine mechanisms are tools of broad rationality. They ask: was this preference produced by learning and reflection, or by deprivation and constraint? Thin rationality cannot tell the difference. Broad rationality demands that we look.

[PRESENTATION TIP: Keep both columns visible. Point to the left column and say "Aarav passes this test." Point to the right column and say "This is the test that won't let us rest." Then remove the slide and return to the story.]

THE MIRROR — From One Person to a Society | 18:30–24:00

VISUAL: Pull outward from the shop to the whole neighbourhood. Workshops, students walking toward a coaching centre, crowded streets.

A government planner surveys residents about a proposed education and skills centre.

> ***Resident 1:*** *What will we do with it? We need work now.*
>
> ***Resident 2:*** *Our children should study, but fees and transport are the problem.*
>
> ***Resident 3:*** *We're managing. Why spend money on something people may not use?*

The planner concludes: the community does not want further education. The centre is cancelled. The budget is redirected.

NARRATOR:

The community's preferences have been respected. But those preferences may have formed under the same pressures we watched in Aarav's life — scaled to thousands of people. When an entire community has adapted to deprivation, aggregating their preferences does not escape the problem. It magnifies it.

This is where Sen's critique of utilitarian evaluation becomes structural. Traditional utilitarian social choice rests on three pillars:

[VISUAL: Three pillars on screen.]

- **Welfarism** — evaluate a society through people's reported utility.
- **Sum-ranking** — add those utilities together.
- **Consequentialism** — judge a policy by the state of affairs it produces.

If preferences have adapted to deprivation, welfarism records that adaptation as satisfaction. Sum-ranking aggregates it. Consequentialism calls the outcome acceptable. The framework is internally consistent — and blind to the process that produced the numbers.

A related concept: **Pareto optimality** — a state in which no one can be made better off without making someone worse off. A neighbourhood can be Pareto optimal and deeply unjust at the same time. Optimality is an efficiency criterion, not a moral verdict.

[Remove the pillars. Show the neighbourhood again.]

The Industrialisation Paradox

NARRATOR:

Consider a harder case. Before industrialisation, a community's wants are modest and mostly met. People report contentment. Then industry arrives — new jobs, new goods, new horizons — but also new inequality, new disruption, new aspirations that cannot yet be fulfilled.

Reported satisfaction may *fall* even as real possibilities expand.

Should we preserve the earlier state because people were happier? Or accept the frustrations of transition because the world has opened up?

A policy that preserves low aspirations because they produce high satisfaction risks making adaptation into a reason to never change anything. But a policy that imposes change because outsiders think they know better risks destroying autonomy in the name of freedom.

There is no clean exit from this dilemma. There is only the obligation to see it clearly — and to ensure that when opportunities expand, people have a genuine say in what happens next.

THE ENDING — A Pencil in His Hand | 24:00–29:00

VISUAL: A quiet classroom. Sunlight across empty desks. The scholarship form on a table. Return to the ceiling fan from the opening. No triumphant music.

NARRATOR:

Three possible futures.

First. Aarav takes the scholarship. He studies engineering, discovers new capacities, builds a life he could not have imagined from inside the repair shop. His preferences change because he has finally been exposed to the alternative. This is learning — genuine, experience-based revision.

Second. He takes it, struggles, and returns to repair work. Not in defeat — in knowledge. He has seen both lives from the inside and chosen the one that fits. The preference for the shop is now informed, not assumed.

Third. He declines after honest reflection. He chooses his craft, his family, a life shaped by values he has deliberately examined. This is not adaptation. It is a considered decision about what kind of life he wants to lead.

Which future is best? I cannot answer that by comparing incomes or degrees. And I should not answer it by assuming that more education is automatically a better life.

The ethical question was never *"Should Aarav become an engineer?"*

It was: *Does he have a genuine opportunity to decide — and have the conditions around him allowed that decision to be truly his?*

[Aarav sits at the table. The form in front of him. He picks up a pencil — the same kind from the opening scene.]

> ***Aarav:*** *(quietly) What do I actually want?*

[Hold the image. Five seconds of silence.]

NARRATOR:

A just society does not make people content by narrowing what they dare to want. It expands the conditions under which people form and exercise their choices — and then respects what they choose, even when they choose differently from what we would have chosen for them.

Elster does not argue that every change in preference is irrational. He argues that we must examine how preferences are formed before treating their satisfaction as proof that all is well.

Sen does not argue that freedom replaces happiness. He argues that happiness alone is too narrow a window through which to see a life.

Together, they leave us with a question that has no comfortable answer:

WHEN WE GIVE SOMEONE THE FREEDOM TO CHOOSE, WHO GETS TO DECIDE WHAT FREEDOM SHOULD LOOK LIKE?

[Silence. Hold the slide. End.]

Quick Reference — For the Presenter Only

Elster's Nine Mechanisms (each appears once in the story)

#	Mechanism	Scene
1	Adaptive preferences	Aarav decides engineering "isn't worth it" (6 months)
2	Counteradaptive preferences	Deepa's obsession with medicine (same week)
3	Learning	The factory placement (9 months)
4	Precommitment	"Hide the form until January" (1 year)
5	Manipulation	Sharma uncle's partnership pitch (13 months)
6	Character planning	The rooftop reflection (15 months)
7	Attribute weights	Father's hospitalisation (18 months)
8	Addiction	Ravi's drinking (20 months)
9	Rationalization + State-dependence	"Engineers are unemployed" / "If money weren't a problem..." (2 years)

Where each theory concept appears (once only)

Concept	Location in script
Adaptive preference formation (sour grapes)	Episode 1 — six months in
Sen's capability argument	The Knock — after mother's conversation
Thin vs. broad rationality	Split-screen section after Sen
Welfarism / sum-ranking / consequentialism	The Mirror — three pillars
Pareto optimality	The Mirror — after the pillars
Industrialisation paradox	The Mirror — final section
Central argument	The Ending — narrator's last lines

Thin vs. Broad Rationality — Presentation Guide

How to present it:

1. Put up a **split screen** — two columns, "Thin Rationality" on the left, "Broad Rationality" on the right.
2. **Left column:** Say — *"Thin rationality asks: does this person act consistently with what they believe and want? Aarav does. His actions match his preferences. He passes this test."*
3. **Right column:** Say — *"Broad rationality asks: how did those beliefs and preferences form? Were they shaped by reflection and genuine choice — or by circumstances that left no real alternative? This is the harder question."*
4. **Key line:** *"Elster's nine mechanisms are tools of broad rationality. They don't check whether Aarav is consistent — they ask how he became consistent with this particular set of desires."*
5. Remove the slide and return to the story. Do not revisit this distinction again — it has been made.